O Tannenbaum, o Tannenbaum…

Then we replied.

O come all ye faithful…

But this time they joined in, singing the words in Latin.

Adeste fideles…

Britain and Germany harmonizing across No Man's Land! I would have thought nothing could be more amazing – but what came next was even more so.

"English, come over!" we heard one of them shout. "You no shoot, we no shoot."

There in the trenches, we looked at each other in bewilderment. Then one of us shouted jokingly, "You come over here."

To our astonishment, we saw two figures rise from a trench, climb over their barbed wire, and advance unprotected across No Man's Land. One of them called, "Send officer to talk."

I saw one of our men lift his rifle to the ready, and no doubt others did the same - but our captain called out, "Hold your fire." Then he climbed out and went to meet the Germans halfway.

We heard them talking, and a few minutes later, the captain came back and announced, "We've agreed that there will be no shooting before midnight tomorrow. But sentries are to remain on duty, and the rest of you, stay alert."

Across the way, we could make out groups of two or three men starting out of trenches and coming towards us. Then some of us climbed out too, and in minutes, there we were in No Man's Land – over a hundred soldiers and officers of each side, shaking hands with men we'd been trying to kill just hours earlier!

Before long, a bonfire was built and around it we mingled – British khaki and German grey. I must say, the Germans were the better dressed, with fresh uniforms for the holiday.

Only a couple of our men knew German, but more of the Germans knew English. I asked one of them why that was so.

"Because many have worked in England!" he said. "Before all this, I was a waiter at the Hotel Cecil. Perhaps I waited on your table!"

"Perhaps you did!" I said, laughing.

Another German had been a porter at Victoria Station. He showed me a picture of his family back in Munich. It was so lovely, I told him I would like to meet his family members someday. He happily gave me his family's address.

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